TIM O'BRIEN

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Education

University of Chicago — Chicago, IL
M.A. in International Relations, with Honors (GPA: 3.88) — 2025 – 2026
B.A. in Political Science, with Honors (GPA: 3.75) — 2021 – 2025

London School of Economics — London, UK
The General Course, International Relations (GPA: 3.93) — 2023 – 2024

Research

Innovation without Democratization: The Political Limits of Technological Change
M.A. Thesis, University of Chicago. Advisor: Scott Gehlbach.
Abstract: *Innovation has been positively linked to a variety of economic outcomes, including long-run development, productivity, and human capital. But its political effects have received far less attention. To address this imbalance, I investigate the effect of innovation on democracy and two intermediate outcomes, state capacity and capital mobility, using a shift-share instrumental variables strategy on a panel of 187 countries from 1995 to 2015. This design exploits quasi-random variation in global patenting growth across different fields of knowledge to identify the effects of innovation. I find that innovation exerts no detectable effect on democracy, but strongly and positively increases both state capacity and capital mobility. I argue that the null effect of innovation on democracy stems from the offsetting influences of these two forces. State capacity reduces the elites' costs of repression and therefore inhibits democratization, while capital mobility decreases the costs of conceding to democracy and thus promotes it.*

Does Economic Globalization Promote Democracy? An Empirical Investigation into the Political Consequences of Economic Integration
Berkeley Economic Review, forthcoming 2026. B.A. Thesis. Advisor: Susan Stokes.

Work Experience

Saïd Business School, University of Oxford — Feb 2026 – Present
Research Fellow, Prof. Kejia Hu

- Implement LLM-based batch inference to test result robustness in managerial economics studies
- Conduct Monte Carlo simulations to assess bias in regression-based estimators
- Reproduce published regressions from authors' replication packages

Knowledge Lab, University of Chicago — Nov 2025 – Present
Research Assistant, Prof. James Evans and Dr. Nadav Kunievsky

- Build Python and LLM pipelines matching 26,000 grant applications to 300 million publications
- Conduct econometric analysis on research funding effects in R, Python, and Stata
- Develop classification models using supervised and unsupervised deep learning

Chicago Council on Global Affairs — Jan 2025 – Sep 2025
Intern, Public Opinion and U.S. Foreign Policy

- Cleaned and maintained large-scale proprietary survey datasets on U.S. foreign policy issues
- Produced topline reports on American public opinion toward Asia, Europe, Ukraine, the Middle East, trade policy, and multilateralism
- Published analysis on European attitudes toward the U.S. in the *Running Numbers* blog

Chicago Project on Security and Threats, University of Chicago Jun 2023 – Aug 2023
Research Assistant, Prof. Robert Pape

– Updated the "Threats Matrix" database (2001–2023) of threats toward American politicians

– Aided in the revision and implementation of standardized data-coding protocols for the research team

– Created data visualizations and case studies on charged perpetrators of threats

Awards and Honors

Honors, M.A. in International Relations, University of Chicago 2026
Awarded to the top 15% of the cohort on the basis of the M.A. Thesis.

M.A. Director's Merit Scholarship, University of Chicago 2025
Merit award from the Committee on International Relations.

Teaching and Service

University of Chicago, Department of Political Science Jan 2025 – Apr 2025
Undergraduate Advisor

– Evaluated job talks by 6 candidates for 2 instructional professorships in social science methodology

– Advised prospective political science majors on coursework and career paths

University of Chicago Neighborhood Schools Program Nov 2022 – Jun 2023
Teaching Assistant

– Tutored ∼50 low-income students on Chicago's South Side as part of a UChicago student team

Skills

Coursework: Mathematics for Social Science (Calculus, Linear Algebra, Probability Theory), Applied Regression Analysis, Causal Inference, Machine Learning, Hierarchical Linear Models, Multivariable Calculus and Linear Algebra (Winter 2027)
Software: R, Python, Stata, SQL, LaTeX, Git, Bash, SLURM
Languages: English (native), Spanish (working proficiency)
Interests: Rubik's Cube speedsolving (top 0.03% worldwide), basketball

References

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Professor Susan Stokes
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Dr. Nadav Kunievsky
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